

Policy Brief

The following is a concise policy brief with findings, recommendations, and gaps for Delaware's civic engagement strategy.

Summary

The strongest civic education is characterized by a mutual relationship between civic knowledge and civic participation. A state might have strong civic education on paper but if there are not high rates of civic engagement then there is a gap there that needs to be resolved. Civic education is essential and should give individuals real power rather than symbolic engagement. Students might learn about civic education, but if they are not prepared to practice it, then reforms need to be made.

Findings

Delaware has a strong civic education model on paper and relatively decent averages of civic engagement, but there is room for improvement. Delaware teaches students about civic education through elementary, middle school, and high school courses but there is no mandate of a civics course required for high school graduation unlike in many other states. Delaware also does not well serve marginalized communities despite attempts at equity. Their public policies do not marginalize certain groups, but they do not empower them either.

Gaps

The main gap for Delaware is the gap between civic engagement and civic education. Delaware needs to do better to serve marginalized communities equally, and there is no mandated civics test required for high school graduation which is another gap. The history and contributions of people of color, disabled individuals, and LGBTQ individuals are not taught either. There are also gaps with organizations missing in community infrastructure mapping.

Recommendations

There are 3 important recommendations for Delaware's civic education strategy. The first recommendation is to implement a choice of either a required civics test or a mandatory civics project upon high school graduation. Providing the option to do either or provides more flexibility, depending on whether a student feels like they are a better test taker or if they better express their knowledge through creativity. The second policy recommendation for Delaware is to implement more resources and teachings to include marginalized communities in civic education. Mandatory teachings should be integrated into course concepts, and they specifically could be centered around the contributions and history of multiple marginalized groups to ensure that all voices are heard and are given power. The third policy recommendation is to develop a Civics Hub. This Civics Hub could be a center that could possibly implement an after-school program for individuals who need a place to focus on schoolwork or feel integrated into their community through civic empowerment. It would be focused on supporting marginalized communities, including unhoused individuals or students who need after school care if their parents

work. This would be a safe and accessible space for all, with access to resources such as healthcare support, civic engagement support, and teaching resources.

Conclusion

There is room for improvement for Delaware to close the gap between civic engagement and civic participation. It will take time, money, effort, and support from policy holders. It is essential to analyze the impact of policy solutions on all stakeholders and take action to bring about equity in the community. Research has consistently shown that inclusion of marginalized communities in civic education directly correlates with higher rates of community civic engagement. Through a civics hub, resources, teachings, and a choice of project or a test are important recommendations to ensure a community where all voices are heard and individuals do not fear running a risk if they are involved in civic participation.